FROM THE FLOOR

The monthly magazine of Stiven Catalyst



ROLE

THE MANAGER IN THE MIDDLE

Data, AI and the decision: why engagement falls most among managers, who trains them, how large their teams have grown, how AI arrives through them, and answers from the floor.

22% of managers worldwide were engaged at work in 2025, down from 31% in 2022.

GALLUP, 2026

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In this issue

Targets from above, problems from the floor, data, and now AI: they all meet at the manager. This issue asks what the latest figures say about the person in the middle, and what an organisation can do for them tomorrow.

Only 20% of employees worldwide were engaged in 2025, and managers fell furthest: from 31% in 2022 to 22%. Fewer than half say they were ever trained for the role, their teams have grown, and AI now arrives through them. Stiven Janaqi answers from the floor: a manager who reacts to everything becomes part of the problem. A simple rhythm and the KPI Diagnostic close the issue.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

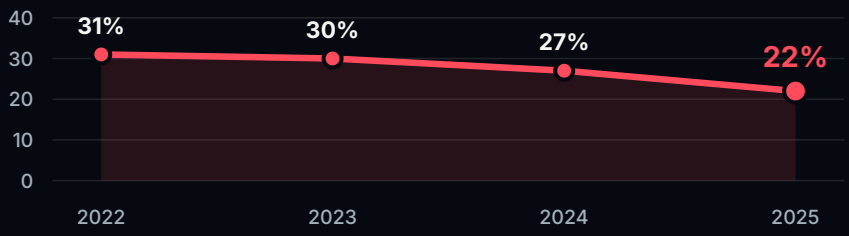
Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

TREND OF THE MONTH

The manager in the middle

Only 20% of employees worldwide were engaged at work in 2025, down from 23% in 2022. The steepest fall was among managers.

ENGAGED MANAGERS WORLDWIDE, 2022–2025



19%
of employees without a management role were engaged in 2025

12%
in Europe, the lowest region (three-year average)

70%
of the variance in a team's engagement is linked to its manager

OUR READING

For years managers were clearly more engaged than their teams. That advantage has almost disappeared, and what happens to the manager does not stay with the manager.

Sources: Gallup, 2026; Gallup, 2015

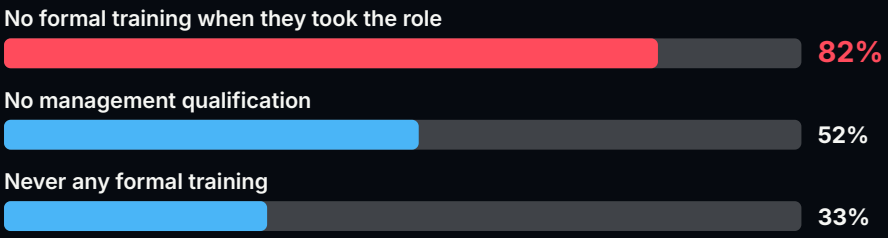
Engagement as Gallup measures it, data for 2025. The 70% is Gallup's estimate across business units (2015).

THE NUMBERS

Promoted, not prepared

Less than half of the world's managers, 44%, say they have received management training. Half as many of those who were trained are actively disengaged as of those who were not.

UK MANAGERS AND FORMAL MANAGEMENT TRAINING (2023)



44%

of managers worldwide say they have received management training (2024)

GALLUP, 2025

79%

of managers were engaged in best-practice organisations in 2025, nearly four times the world

GALLUP, 2026

OUR READING

Many people are promoted because they are good at the operational work. The decline is not a law of nature: where managers are prepared, it does not happen.

Sources: Gallup, 2025; Gallup, 2026; Chartered Management Institute, 2023

Gallup's training figures are from the 2025 report (data for 2024); the report gives no shares for the actively disengaged. CMI: YouGov, 2,524 UK managers, June 2023.

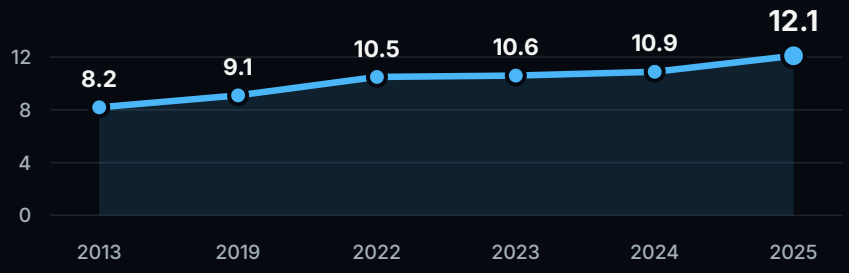
More in the essay The first 30 days: how I read an operation I do not know

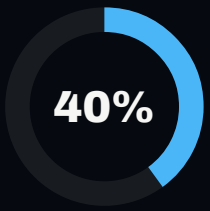
THE NUMBERS

Larger teams, not everywhere

In the US the average number of direct reports per manager rose from 8.2 in 2013 to 12.1 in 2025, because some teams became very large. The median stays at about 5 to 6.

AVERAGE NUMBER OF DIRECT REPORTS, MANAGERS AND LEADERS IN THE US





of their time, the median, US managers spend on individual contributor work; 97% have some of it besides leading others.

OUR READING

The number on the org chart says little. The question is how many people a manager can really give the attention the role demands.

Source: Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026

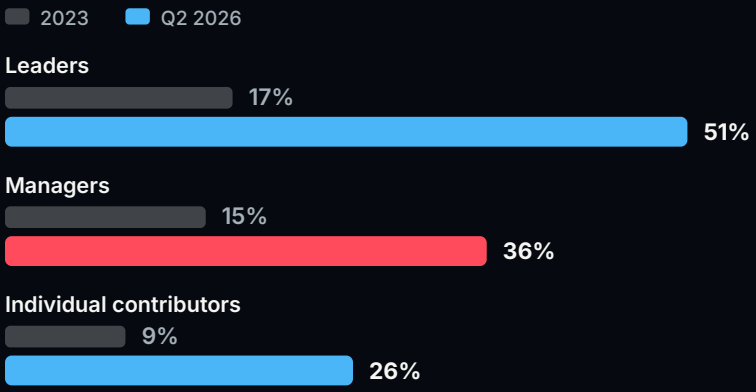
Gallup's US panel; the average includes leaders with very large spans. The span of control is the subject of Management Review No. 57.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

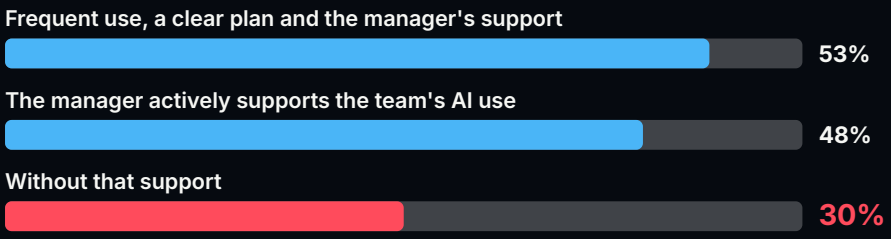
AI arrives through the manager

Frequent use of AI at work, a few times a week or more, has risen at every level in the US since 2023, fastest among leaders. Whether teams follow depends on their manager.

US EMPLOYEES USING AI A FEW TIMES A WEEK OR MORE



ENGAGED EMPLOYEES IN ORGANISATIONS THAT HAVE BROUGHT IN AI (2026)



A prediction, not a measurement: in October 2024 Gartner predicted that through 2026, 20% of organisations would use AI to flatten their structure, eliminating more than half of current middle management positions.

Sources: Gallup, 2026; Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026; Gartner, 2024 (via Network World, 22 October 2024)

Gallup Panel, US. Engagement: Q1–Q2 2026, employees whose organisation has brought in AI. Gartner's release quoted by Network World.

FROM THE FLOOR

Signal or noise

Stiven Janaqi has been a Team Leader and an Area Manager in last-mile logistics and works today as a Night Auditor in hospitality.

When you were promoted, what took most of your energy?

When I moved from a role closer to the operation to Area Manager, after about five months, the challenge was no longer only solving the problems of the moment. I had 4 Shift Leaders and 8 Dispatchers reporting to me directly, while the operation included around 250 drivers indirectly. Most of my energy went into moving constantly from one problem to the next: KPIs, delays, quality, damage, loading, safety, and people who needed decisions or support.

What wears you out is not always the size of a problem. It is the number of small problems that need attention at the same time.

Did you get management training?

What would have helped me a lot is an onboarding made for the move from operator to manager: how to prioritise, how to delegate, how to give feedback, how to develop people, and how to tell a problem that needs you from a problem the team should solve itself.

Many people are promoted because they are good at the operational work. But the manager's job needs a different set of skills.

Does it ring true that managers can be as disengaged as their teams?

Yes, it seems credible from what I have seen. Not because managers do not want to do their job, but because they are often the point where all the pressures gather. From above come the targets, the KPIs and the deadlines. From below come people's problems, absences, conflicts and the reality of the operation. In between are the reports, the meetings and the admin.

When this goes on for long, a manager can slide from leading the team to reacting to problems. At that point the energy for coaching, development and improvement is gone.

FROM THE FLOOR

How many direct reports are too many in operations?

I do not believe in a universal number. It depends on how complex the work is and how autonomous the people are. But from my experience, 12 direct reports in a fast-paced operation is already a serious span. If each of them needs feedback, coaching, problem-solving and escalation, the quality of management can drop very quickly.

The problem is not only how many people you have on the org chart. The question is: how many of them can you really give the attention your role demands?

One thing an organisation could do tomorrow for its first-line managers?

Give them clarity on priorities and take away part of the administrative noise. A first-line manager should not spend most of the day producing reports about the work they should be managing.

I would set up a simple rhythm: a few KPIs that matter, open problems with a clear owner, a short moment for the people, and a defined channel for escalation. If everything is a priority, in the end the manager only reacts.

> ***When I started leading larger operations, I thought my job was to have as many answers as possible. Over time I understood that the most valuable part of the role was knowing which problems really needed my attention. A manager who reacts to everything quickly becomes part of the problem. A manager who tells the signal from the noise can start building a system.***

STIVEN JANAQI

A QUESTION FOR YOU

How much of your day as a manager goes into reacting to problems, and how much into building what prevents them?

THE PRACTICE

A simple rhythm

Stiven Janaqi's answer to what an organisation could do tomorrow, as a card for the week: a few KPIs that matter, open problems with an owner, a moment for the people, one channel for escalation.

01 **Three KPIs that matter this week** and the one that is red

02 **Open problems, each with an owner** name and date, not “the team”

03 **A moment for the people** who needs feedback or help this week

04 **The escalation channel** what goes up, to whom, by when

05 **One report I can stop** the administrative noise to take away

A practice proposed by the editors after Stiven Janaqi's answer on page 8. If everything is a priority, in the end the manager only reacts.

More in the essay When to solve it yourself and when to take it higher

TOOL OF THE MONTH

The KPI Diagnostic

A number turned red. Before you push harder, find out where the cause sits. Ten statements show whether it lies in clarity, skill, capacity, process design or ownership, with three first moves and a question for the floor. It takes about two minutes, and nothing you enter is stored or sent.

From a red number to a change

1. Red KPI
2. segment
3. find the concentration
4. go to the process
5. ask why
6. try a change
7. measure again

“A KPI does not give you the answer. It shows you where to start asking questions.”

More in the essay — KPIs do not improve in Excel

Open the tool: KPI Diagnostic — stivencatalyst.com/tools/kpi-diagnostic/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

State of the Global Workplace: 2026 Report
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/349484/state-of-the-global-workplace.aspx

State of the Global Workplace: 2025 Report
Gallup, 2025
https://www.gallup.com/file/workplace/659528/state-of-the-global-workplace-2025-download.pdf

State of the American Manager
Gallup, 2015
https://www.gallup.com/services/182138/state-american-manager.aspx

Better Management Report: Taking responsibility
Chartered Management Institute, 2023
https://www.managers.org.uk/knowledge-and-insights/research/better-management-report-take-responsibility-take-action/

Span of Control: What's the Optimal Team Size for Managers?
Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/700718/span-control-optimal-team-size-managers.aspx

AI and Workplace Productivity: What Leaders Need to Know
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/713063/ai-workplace-productivity.aspx

Employee Engagement Remains Flat as AI Adoption Accelerates
Jim Harter, Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/712433/employee-engagement-remains-flat-adoption-accelerates.aspx

Gartner Unveils Top Predictions for IT Organizations and Users in 2025 and Beyond
Gartner, 2024 · via Network World, 22 October 2024
https://www.gartner.com/en/newsroom/press-releases/2024-10-22-gartner-unveils-top-predictions-for-it-organizations-and-users-in-2025-and-beyond

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



FROM THE FLOOR

The monthly magazine of Stiven Catalyst

Every month one theme of the work on the floor, checked against the research, with answers from the floor.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/from-the-floor.html